

# Cedarfield After Dark

*A companion guide for adult readers of Harlan Coben's The Stranger (2015), for solo readers and book clubs.*

### Fan-made. Use alongside your own copy.

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Contains 1 chapter. Each chapter begins on a new page, so you can stop where you are without reading ahead.

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# How to use this guide

Read a chapter of the novel first, then turn to that chapter here. Every chapter has the same parts:

- **What happens**: a summary in fresh words and a scene-by-scene list, to refresh your memory or catch what you missed.
- **Thirty questions**: moving from what happened, to how it's written, to what it means. Six are marked for book clubs because they start real disagreements.
- **Three close-reading exercises**: each tells you where to find the passage (chapter and scene, since page numbers differ by edition) and walks you through it step by step.
- **Ninety activities**: nine for each of the ten rooms, each taking 15 to 60 minutes, with a box to tick.
- **Six cross-room projects** with checklists, **three essay or writing prompts**, and **nine further readings**, all of which are real, published works.

You don't need to do everything. A book club might take two marked questions and one project per meeting. A solo reader might choose one room and follow it through the whole book. A student might work through all three close readings.

The website version adds interactive tools (sixty of them), a spoiler guard that hides later chapters, painted rooms with ambient sound, a narrator called Dot, hidden curios, seven secret rooms behind riddles, and a commonplace book that collects your notes.

## A note on quotations

In copyright (© 2015 Harlan Coben). This companion quotes nothing from the novel; every summary and prompt is written fresh, and passages are cited by chapter and scene so you can find them in any edition.

Room guide

# The rooms of Cedarfield

The guide is organised as a walk through an invented New Jersey town at night. Each room is a place from the novel's world and a way of reading.

## American Legion Hall

**Main room · your ledger.** Where it starts. Set your chapter, check your ledger, collect what you have found, and talk to Dot.

Draft night. Folding chairs in a circle, neon beer signs, a sticky bar, and a stranger who knows something.

## Adam's Law Office

**Close reading & style.** Read like a lawyer reads a contract: slowly, for what each sentence is doing. Prose rhythm, voice, point of view, chapter endings.

A four-storey glass box on Midland Avenue, Paramus. One desk lamp still on after everyone has gone.

## Room 233, Cedarfield High

**Themes & ideas.** Secrets, surveillance, the suburban dream, parenthood, money, trust. Track the ideas the novel keeps returning to.

A 1970s school gone grey, aqua trim fading. Corinne's homeroom, with a substitute at the desk.

## Town Hall Records Room

**History & the author's life.** Coben's New Jersey, the internet of 2015, eminent domain, youth sport, and the real history behind the fiction.

Dented filing cabinets, a wall clock that runs fast, and the ranking that made Cedarfield proud.

## Public Library Stacks

**Sources & influences.** What this novel is in conversation with: Ibsen, Hawthorne, Conan Doyle's blackmailer, suburban fiction, and Coben's own shelf.

Modern library, quiet aisle, one flickering tube. Somebody has left a mythology book open on a cart.

## The Turnpike

**Setting & geography.** Bergen County to Beachwood, Ohio, to a lake past the Delaware. Maps, distances, places and what they mean.

Toll plaza lights at 2 a.m. Every journey in this book leaves a record somewhere.

## The Lacrosse Field

**Philosophy & ethics.** Is it right to tell? What do we owe family versus everyone else? Weigh the novel's dilemmas with real ethical tools.

New turf under floodlights. Parents in folding chairs, fathers with crossed arms, a referee everyone is shouting at.

## The Incident Board

**Writing craft.** How a Coben thriller is built: braided strands, short chapters, planted clues, misdirection and the turn.

A corkboard in a station back office: photos, index cards, red string, a coffee ring.

## The All-Night Diner

**Art & music.** Seventies cover-band songs, Springsteen, suburban photography, night painting. Make the book's soundtrack and colours.

Chrome, vinyl booths and a jukebox that only plays the seventies. The coffee is free if you look tired enough.

## The Price Kitchen

**Food & making.** What people eat in this novel says who they are. Cook it, make things, and talk about it at the table.

A granite island the colour of strong coffee, homework spread across the table, every light in the house left on.

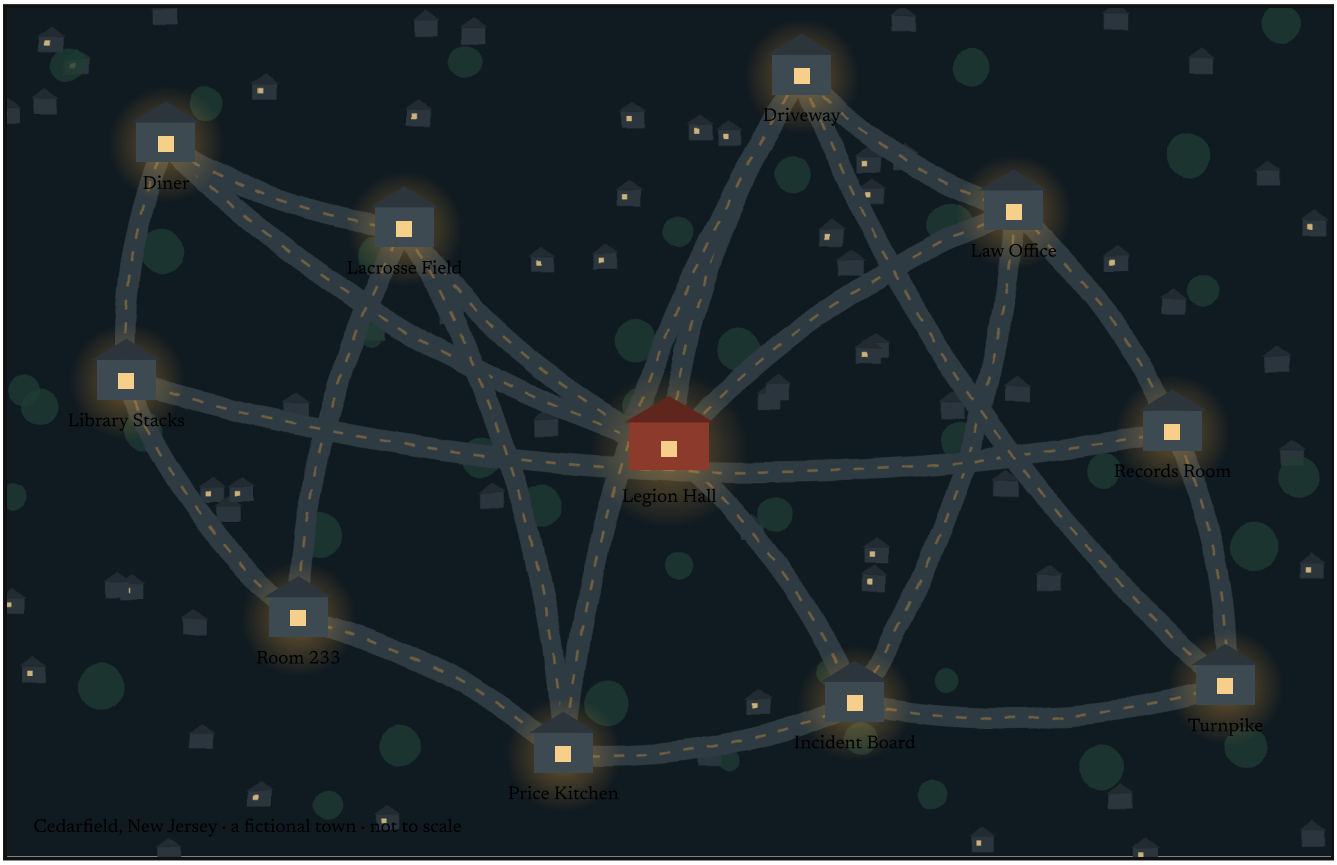
### The Dark Driveway

**Reflective journal.** Sit in the car before you go inside. Your private journal, predictions, moods and the letters you would never send.

Adam's car in the driveway, engine off. Upstairs, both boys' windows glow.

# Map of the town

Cedarfield is fictional. Lit buildings are rooms; roads show which rooms open onto each other.




## Which room for what

- **Law Office**: Close reading & style. Next door: Legion Hall, Records Room, Incident Board, Driveway.
- **Room 233**: Themes & ideas. Next door: Lacrosse Field, Library Stacks, Price Kitchen.
- **Records Room**: History & the author's life. Next door: Law Office, Library Stacks, Turnpike.
- **Library Stacks**: Sources & influences. Next door: Records Room, Room 233, Diner.
- **Turnpike**: Setting & geography. Next door: Records Room, Driveway, Incident Board.
- **Lacrosse Field**: Philosophy & ethics. Next door: Legion Hall, Room 233, Price Kitchen, Diner.
- **Incident Board**: Writing craft. Next door: Legion Hall, Law Office, Turnpike, Price Kitchen.
- **Diner**: Art & music. Next door: Legion Hall, Library Stacks, Lacrosse Field.
- **Price Kitchen**: Food & making. Next door: Room 233, Lacrosse Field, Incident Board, Driveway.
- **Driveway**: Reflective journal. Next door: Legion Hall, Law Office, Price Kitchen, Turnpike.

Chapter 1 of 56 · told through Adam

# 1. Draft Night

## What happens

The novel opens with a confession about memory. Adam Price, a lawyer and father of two, will later try to tell himself that his life came apart slowly, but the narration catches him in the lie at once: he knew from the first sentence a stranger spoke to him that something was over. We are in the American Legion Hall in Cedarfield, New Jersey, a wealthy commuter town whose bankers and fund managers like drinking cheap beer under neon signs because it lets them play at being ordinary guys.

It is draft night for the boys' lacrosse league, the evening when fathers decide which fourth-, fifth- and sixth-graders make the travel teams. Adam is only here because his wife, Corinne, the league's treasurer, is at a teachers' conference in Atlantic City. A thin young man in a baseball cap, pale and earnest with startling blue eyes, sidles up to him at the bar and tells him, in a voice that sounds almost kind, that he never needed to stay with his wife. Two years ago Corinne told Adam she was pregnant; then she miscarried. According to the stranger, none of it was real: the test, the sonogram, the growing belly were all fakes, bought to win him back.

Adam pushes back with what he saw with his own eyes, and the stranger knocks each item down before he can finish. He offers a way to check, a charge on the family credit card under an odd name, and then, as the league president, Tripp Evans, calls the fathers to their folding chairs, he leans close and suggests Adam test whether his two sons are really his. Then he is gone, leaving Adam with the sensation of a bomb whose timer has started.

### Scene by scene

1. The narrator admits that Adam's later version of events, that it all fell apart gradually, is itself a lie.
2. Setting: the American Legion Hall, Cedarfield's rich men slumming at a sticky bar under beer neon.
3. A gaunt young man in a cap tells Adam he didn't have to stay with his wife.
4. Draft night explained: fathers choosing travel teams, Adam standing in for Corinne, the league treasurer.
5. The stranger claims Corinne faked a pregnancy and a miscarriage; he rebuts the test, the sonogram and the belly.
6. Tripp Evans, league president and former Madison Avenue ad man, calls the meeting to order and notices Adam's face.
7. The stranger names a credit-card charge as proof and calls himself a kind of liberator.
8. A parting suggestion: get DNA tests on the boys. The stranger leaves.

### Who's here

| | |
|---|---|
| **Adam Price** | Lawyer, husband, father of two boys; standing in for his wife tonight. |
| **The stranger** | Young, thin, blue-eyed, baseball cap, a hint of a tattoo; speaks gently and with total conviction. |
| **Corinne Price** | Adam's wife, lacrosse-board treasurer, a teacher; away at a conference. |
| **Tripp Evans** | President of the lacrosse league, a former advertising executive and a likeable host. |

## Thirty questions

1. What do we learn about Adam from the fact that he is standing in for his wife tonight?

2. How does the stranger describe himself, and what does his choice of role suggest about how he sees his work?
3. List everything the stranger claims was faked. How does the order of the list increase its force?
4. Where is Corinne, and why does it matter to the plot that she is away?
5. What job does Tripp Evans hold in the league and what did he do before?
6. What proof does the stranger offer, and why might he choose something Adam can check alone, at home?
7. The chapter opens by catching Adam in a lie he will tell himself later. Why might Coben begin a novel about deception this way?
8. How does the narration describe the American Legion Hall and the men in it? What tone is it taking toward Cedarfield?
9. Look at how the stranger speaks: gently, earnestly, almost kindly. Why make him sympathetic rather than menacing?
10. The chapter uses the image of a ticking bomb. What does that image promise the reader about the shape of the book?
11. Notice how the stranger anticipates Adam's objections before he finishes them. What does that tell us about how often he has done this?
12. Why does the stranger's final suggestion, about the boys, land harder than everything before it?
13. How long is this chapter? What does its length do to your reading speed and your expectations?
14. The fathers drag folding chairs into a circle. What other circles, rings or closed groups might the novel be interested in?
15. Who has the power in this scene, and how does it shift between the opening and the close?
16. **Is it ever kind to tell someone a painful truth they did not ask to hear? Does motive matter?** [book club]
17. **If a stranger told you this about your partner, would you check the evidence that night? Be honest.** [book club]
18. Adam is a lawyer. How might that profession shape the way he takes in an accusation?
19. What does the stranger seem to want? List three possibilities and the evidence for each.
20. **The stranger says Adam should be grateful. Under what circumstances, if any, could he be right?** [book club]
21. Why set the opening at a children's sports draft rather than, say, a bar in the city?
22. What does the phrase "living the dream", which the town will soon use, mean before anyone has said it here?
23. Which detail about the stranger's appearance would you remember if you had to describe him to the police?
24. **How does Coben make the reader complicit, so that we also start to suspect Corinne?** [book club]
25. What do you predict Adam will do in the next hour? Write it down before you read on.
26. **Is a lie about a pregnancy worse, the same, or less bad than other lies inside a marriage? Why?** [book club]
27. **The stranger suggests one lie implies others. Is that a fair inference about people?** [book club]
28. What is the effect of starting in the middle of a crowd, with an intimate secret delivered in public?
29. What does this chapter withhold from us that a different novelist might have told us straight away?
30. If you had only this chapter, what genre would you say the book belongs to? What made you think so?

## Close reading

### 1. The lie in the first lines

*Find it: Chapter 1, the opening paragraph: Adam's later account of how his world broke, and the narrator's correction.*

1. Read the opening paragraph twice, once quickly, once slowly.
2. Mark the moment where the narration contradicts what Adam will later tell himself.
3. Note who is speaking: is this Adam, a narrator close to Adam, or someone looking back from after the events?
4. Write one sentence describing how the paragraph handles time (now, then, later).

**Why does a novel about secrets open by showing its own hero deceiving himself? What contract does that make with the reader?**

### 2. Rhythm of an accusation

*Find it: Chapter 1, the middle: the exchange in which Adam lists what he saw (test, sonogram) and the stranger answers each item.*

1. Find the run of short lines of dialogue where Adam offers evidence and the stranger dismisses it.
2. Count the words in each line. Where are the shortest?
3. Notice what the stranger adds that Adam has not mentioned.
4. Read it aloud with a partner, one taking each part, and note where the tempo quickens.

**How does the shape of the dialogue, call and swift reply, do the work of persuasion before the content does?**

### 3. The sting in the tail

*Find it: Chapter 1, the close: the stranger's parting suggestion and his exit as the meeting begins.*

1. Locate the final suggestion and the line that follows it.
2. Compare the stranger's tone here with his tone at the start.
3. Look at how the scene ends: who moves, who is left standing.
4. Note the image the narration uses for what has just happened to Adam.

**Why save the cruellest suggestion for last, and why leave Adam with no chance to respond?**

## Activities by room

### Adam's Law Office: Close reading & style

*Read the first paragraph like a cross-examination transcript. The narration impeaches its own witness, Adam, before he has said a word. Note the comic precision of the social description, the beer neon and the bankers slumming, and how quickly it gives way to short, punched dialogue. Style here is pace: long observant sentences for the room, short ones for the wounds.*

- [ ] **The first-sentence audit** (25 min) Copy the novel's first sentence in your notebook by hand. Then write three alternative openings for the same scene: one starting with the stranger's words, one with the setting, one with Adam's feelings. Which does the most work and why?

- [ ] **Dialogue tempo map** (30 min) Draw a line down a page. On the left, write Adam's lines in this chapter as one-word summaries; on the right, the stranger's. Mark which lines are questions. What pattern emerges in who asks and who answers?
- [ ] **Free indirect style hunt** (30 min) Find three sentences where the narration slips into Adam's own voice (slang, sarcasm, private judgement) without quotation marks. Rewrite each in a neutral narrator's voice and compare what is lost.
- [ ] **The ticking image** (20 min) Track the bomb-and-timer image. Note where it appears and how it is phrased (in your own words). Write a paragraph on why a cliché can be effective when used knowingly.
- [ ] **Social satire in a sentence** (25 min) Choose the sentence that best mocks Cedarfield's fathers. Identify the techniques: specific brand names, comparison, irony. Write your own sentence satirising a group you belong to, using the same tools.
- [ ] **Description of a stranger** (20 min) List every physical detail given about the stranger. Sort them into "would help identify him" and "tells us how to feel about him". What is the balance?
- [ ] **Reading aloud** (30 min) Read the whole chapter aloud, timing yourself. Then reread one paragraph slowly, pausing at every punctuation mark. Note where the prose wants to speed up.
- [ ] **Point-of-view swap** (40 min) Rewrite the chapter's final exchange (about 150 words) from the stranger's point of view. What does he notice about Adam that Adam can't see about himself?
- [ ] **Register sampling** (25 min) Find one example each of formal diction, slang, and comic exaggeration. Write a short note on how Coben mixes registers to sound like a smart, wry suburban man.

## Room 233, Cedarfield High: Themes & ideas

*Every major idea of the novel is introduced in a single bar conversation: secrets inside marriages, the gap between a town's polish and its private lives, the ethics of telling, and whether a lie about the past changes the meaning of the present. Ask what the stranger thinks truth is for.*

- [ ] **Concept map: the secret** (30 min) Draw a map with "the secret" at the centre. Branch out to who knows, who might know, who is affected, and what they stand to lose. Add to it as you read.
- [ ] **Kindness versus truth** (25 min) Write two columns: reasons the stranger's act could be kind, and reasons it is cruel. Then write a paragraph deciding which column is longer and why.
- [ ] **Theme sentences** (20 min) Write three one-sentence theme statements the novel might be about, each a claim not a topic (not "secrets", but "secrets protect the keeper more than the kept-from"). Revisit them at chapter 10.
- [ ] **The dream as setting** (30 min) Find every detail that signals wealth or status. What do these say about the life Adam stands to lose? Write 200 words on how a setting can be a theme.
- [ ] **Spouses as a team** (20 min) Adam will soon describe marriage as being on the same side. List what makes a married couple a "team" and what makes them two individuals. Where does the stranger strike?
- [ ] **Who is the stranger?** (15 min) Brainstorm ten possible identities for the stranger, from the plausible to the absurd. Rank them by evidence from this chapter only.
- [ ] **Lies inside lies** (30 min) The chapter opens with a lie Adam tells himself and centres on a lie Corinne allegedly told him. Write about the difference between self-deception and deceiving others.
- [ ] **Public and private** (20 min) The secret is told in a crowded room. Make a list of times in your life when private news arrived in public. How did the setting change it?
- [ ] **Prepare a seminar** (40 min) Choose two questions from the chapter list and plan a 20-minute discussion: an opening question, two follow-ups, and a closing question that connects to your own lives.

## Town Hall Records Room: History & the author's life

*The American Legion, founded in 1919, runs halls across America that serve as cheap bars and civic meeting rooms. Placing wealthy fathers in one is social comedy with a history: the novel was published in 2015, as youth travel sports and suburban affluence both boomed in northern New Jersey, where Coben himself grew up.*

- [ ] **The American Legion** (30 min) Research when and why the American Legion was founded, and what its local posts are for today. Write a paragraph on why Coben might set a rich town's draft night there.
- [ ] **Coben's New Jersey** (30 min) Read a short biography of Harlan Coben from a reliable source. Note where he grew up and studied. List three ways his own background might show in Cedarfield.
- [ ] **Youth travel sports** (35 min) Look up how US youth "travel teams" differ from town leagues. Make notes on cost, time and who can afford them. How does this explain the fathers' intensity?
- [ ] **Lacrosse's origins** (40 min) Research the Indigenous origins of lacrosse, including the Haudenosaunee game. Write 200 words on what is lost or changed when a sport becomes a suburban status marker.
- [ ] **2015 context** (30 min) Make a timeline of the year 2013–2015: smartphones, social media, online privacy debates. Mark what a reader in 2015 would have taken for granted that a reader today might not.
- [ ] **Advertising men** (25 min) Tripp is a former Madison Avenue ad man. Read about the culture of New York advertising agencies. Note how persuasion as a profession might colour a character.
- [ ] **Atlantic City** (20 min) Research Atlantic City's history as a resort and conference town. Why is it a believable place for a teachers' conference and also slightly comic?
- [ ] **Publishing history** (20 min) Find the novel's first publication details: date, publisher, and where it reached on bestseller lists. Note where it sits in Coben's run of standalone thrillers.
- [ ] **Name auction** (15 min) Read the acknowledgments at the end of your copy (they don't spoil the plot) to learn how some names in the novel were chosen. Note which names you meet in chapter 1 and 2.

## Public Library Stacks: Sources & influences

*An outsider arrives with a truth that will blow a family apart: this is the plot of Ibsen's The Wild Duck (1884), in which an idealist insists a household must live in truth. The title also nods, perhaps, to Camus, and the epigraph to Eliot. Keep a list of older stories this one is rewriting.*

- [ ] **The Wild Duck** (40 min) Read a synopsis of Ibsen's The Wild Duck. Compare Gregers Werle, who insists on revealing the truth, with the stranger. Write down two parallels and one difference.
- [ ] **Title echoes** (30 min) Look up three other works called The Stranger or with "stranger" in the title (Camus, Highsmith's Strangers on a Train). Note what the word does in each.
- [ ] **The epigraph** (25 min) Find the epigraph at the front of your copy and its source in Eliot's choruses from The Rock (1934). Write in your own words what the lines warn about and how they fit chapter 1.
- [ ] **Domestic suspense** (25 min) List five novels you know in which a marriage hides a secret. What does each reveal first: the secret, or the fact that there is one? Where does The Stranger sit?
- [ ] **A blackmailer's ancestors** (45 min) Read Conan Doyle's "The Adventure of Charles Augustus Milverton" (1904). Note how Holmes judges a man who trades in secrets. Keep it in mind for later chapters.
- [ ] **Hawthorne's veil** (40 min) Read Hawthorne's short story "The Minister's Black Veil". Write about how a visible secret changes a community's behaviour.
- [ ] **Opening lines compared** (30 min) Collect the first sentences of five thrillers you own or can find in a library. Compare how many begin with a claim about time or memory, as this one does.

- [ ] **Oedipus and the urge to know** (30 min) Read a summary of Sophocles' Oedipus the King. What links a hero who insists on knowing with Adam, who now cannot stop himself from checking?
- [ ] **Your own source list** (15 min) Start a running list of works this novel reminds you of. Add one entry per chapter with a single sentence on why.

## The Turnpike: Setting & geography

*Cedarfield is invented, but it is modelled on the wealthy commuter towns of Bergen County. Atlantic City, a couple of hours south at the shore, is the excuse for Corinne's absence. Map the distance between where she is and where the secret surfaces.*

- [ ] **Locate Cedarfield** (30 min) Cedarfield is fictional. Using a map of Bergen County, NJ, pick three real towns it might be modelled on. Justify your choice from details in the chapter.
- [ ] **Draw the hall** (25 min) Sketch a floor plan of the American Legion Hall from the chapter: bar, dartboard, chair rack, door. Mark where Adam and the stranger stand. Why does space matter here?
- [ ] **Shore and suburb** (15 min) Measure the distance between northern New Jersey and Atlantic City. How long a drive is it? What does the distance mean for how quickly Corinne could be reached?
- [ ] **Status geography** (20 min) Make a list of the markers of a wealthy US suburb (schools, sports facilities, lawns, cars). Find which are already present in chapter 1.
- [ ] **Night setting** (30 min) Write 150 words describing a community hall you know at night, borrowing the novel's method: one physical detail, one social observation, one wry joke.
- [ ] **Commuter towns** (30 min) Research how many residents of a typical Bergen County town commute to Manhattan. How does commuting shape a town's rhythms and relationships?
- [ ] **Insider and outsider** (20 min) Map who belongs in this room and who doesn't. Note what physical or behavioural signs mark the stranger as an outsider.
- [ ] **A sense of season** (15 min) Find clues to the time of year. Why might spring suit a story about the surface of suburban life?
- [ ] **Mapping journal** (20 min) Start a map of the novel you will add to every chapter, with pins for each new place and a note of what happens there.

## The Lacrosse Field: Philosophy & ethics

*The stranger frames himself as a liberator. Is telling an unrequested truth a gift, an assault, or both? Separate the act (disclosure), the motive (unknown), and the consequences (not yet visible). Most ethical judgements of this chapter quietly assume answers to all three.*

- [ ] **The right to know** (40 min) Write a short argument (300 words) for the claim that Adam had a right to this information. Then write the strongest objection.
- [ ] **Motive matters?** (30 min) Imagine three motives for the stranger: money, revenge, principle. Does the moral quality of telling change with each? Explain using one example.
- [ ] **Kantian test** (30 min) Apply Kant's idea that you should act only on a rule you could will everyone to follow. Could "tell people the hidden lies of their spouses" be such a rule?
- [ ] **Consequences ledger** (30 min) List the possible good and bad consequences of the stranger's visit for Adam, Corinne, the boys and the stranger. Weigh them. What can't you know yet?
- [ ] **Privacy and marriage** (30 min) Is there a sphere of privacy inside a marriage? Write about what, if anything, spouses may keep from each other.

- [ ] **Draft-night ethics** (20 min) The league uses rankings to choose children. Identify where fairness and favouritism might already be in play, even before chapter 2 shows us.
- [ ] **Gratitude and harm** (30 min) The stranger says Adam should thank him. Write a dialogue in which Adam explains why he can't.
- [ ] **Veil of ignorance** (30 min) Using Rawls' thought experiment, would you agree to a world in which strangers can reveal spouses' secrets, if you didn't know whether you'd be the deceiver or the deceived?
- [ ] **Personal stance** (20 min) Write a private paragraph: is there something you would rather never know? Why?

## The Incident Board: Writing craft

*A classic hook: a hidden past revealed in the first scene, a credible messenger, a checkable clue, and an escalation at the exit. Notice what Coben withholds: the stranger's name, his source and his reason. A thriller runs on what the reader wants to know next.*

- [ ] **Hook anatomy** (30 min) Break the chapter into four beats: situation, disruption, escalation, exit. Write one line for each. Then sketch the same four beats for an original story of your own.
- [ ] **What's withheld** (20 min) List every question the chapter raises but doesn't answer. Rank them by how badly you want to know. This is the engine of the next 55 chapters.
- [ ] **Clue cards** (20 min) Make index cards for each concrete clue (names, a billing name, timing). Pin them up; you'll connect them as you read.
- [ ] **Messenger design** (25 min) Why is the stranger young, thin and gentle? Write down what would change if he were a menacing older man or a woman. Which version is scariest?
- [ ] **Exit lines** (25 min) Compare the chapter's last line with the endings of three short chapters from any thriller. What are the common moves?
- [ ] **Pacing by length** (15 min) Estimate the word count of chapter 1 and compare with chapters 2 and 3 when you get there. Start a chart; length is a pacing tool.
- [ ] **Scene from the bar** (45 min) Write a 250-word scene in which a stranger tells someone a secret in a public place, using the same structure: claim, objection, proof, sting.
- [ ] **Withholding vs cheating** (20 min) Discuss: when does a thriller's withholding become unfair to the reader? Note a rule you'd apply as a writer.
- [ ] **Characters by function** (15 min) Assign each character so far a story function (protagonist, catalyst, host, absent centre). Who is the absent centre?

## The All-Night Diner: Art & music

*Picture the scene as a painting: harsh bar neon, a room of men in matching white T-shirts and caps, one figure who doesn't belong. Think about colour as character. What colour is the stranger? What colour is Cedarfield?*

- [ ] **Neon palette** (45 min) Paint or collage the Legion Hall at night using only four colours. Pick them to express the mood of the scene, not realism.
- [ ] **A portrait of the stranger** (30 min) Draw the stranger from the description. Leave out his face, or obscure it under the cap. Notice how the description protects him from being seen.
- [ ] **Bar soundtrack** (25 min) Make a five-song playlist for a suburban dads' bar night. Then add one song that would play in Adam's head after the stranger leaves.
- [ ] **Hopper study** (25 min) Look at Edward Hopper's Nighthawks (1942). Write a paragraph comparing its isolation-in-company with Adam's position at the bar.

- [ ] **Group portrait** (20 min) Sketch the circle of folding chairs from above as a pattern. What does a circle mean as a social shape?
- [ ] **Typography of a secret** (20 min) Design a one-word title card for this chapter in a typeface that expresses dread. Explain your choice.
- [ ] **Cover thumbnail** (30 min) Sketch three cover ideas for the novel based only on chapter 1. Keep them original: no film stills or existing covers.
- [ ] **Sound of shock** (20 min) Describe, in 100 words, the sound inside Adam's head after the stranger leaves, using musical terms (tempo, dynamics, silence).
- [ ] **Photograph the ordinary** (40 min) Take three photographs of an everyday public place near you at dusk. Choose the one that looks most like a story is about to happen.

## The Price Kitchen: Food & making

*Food is barely present, only bottles of beer, but drink is doing social work: rich men choosing a working-class beer to perform belonging. Consider what your own town drinks when it wants to look unpretentious.*

- [ ] **Unpretentious drinks** (30 min) Make a list of drinks and foods that signal "regular guy" in your culture. Prepare one and talk about why it has that meaning.
- [ ] **Bar snacks** (40 min) Make a simple bar snack (spiced nuts or popcorn) for your book group and use it as an icebreaker: everyone shares one place they act like someone they're not.
- [ ] **Ledger notebook** (45 min) Start making the treasurer's ledger notebook from the Maker's bench tool: fold and stitch the first signature.
- [ ] **Draft-night list** (20 min) Write a "scouting report" in neat ranked handwriting for an imaginary team of your own friends. Notice how ranking people feels.
- [ ] **Secrets box** (15 min) Begin the secrets box (Maker's bench). Write chapter 1's secret on a slip in your own words and seal it inside.
- [ ] **Kitchen conversation** (30 min) Over a meal, ask: if a stranger told you a secret about someone you love, would you check? Note the range of answers.
- [ ] **Recipe of a scene** (20 min) Write a "recipe" for this chapter: ingredients (characters, setting, a secret), method (steps of the scene), serving suggestion (what it leaves you hungry for).
- [ ] **Menu for the book club** (20 min) Plan the menu for the first meeting, with something from a bar, something from a family kitchen, and something nobody can identify.
- [ ] **Hands-on hall** (45 min) Build a quick model of the hall from a shoebox: bar, chairs, door. Use it to block out where everyone stands.

## The Dark Driveway: Reflective journal

*Sit with the bomb image. Before you read on, note how you felt toward Corinne after these few pages, and toward the stranger. You'll want this first impression later.*

- [ ] **First impressions** (15 min) Write a paragraph on what you think of Corinne, Adam and the stranger right now. Seal it in your journal; reread at chapter 30.
- [ ] **The bell you can't unring** (30 min) Write about a time you learned something you couldn't unlearn. How did it change how you looked at someone?
- [ ] **Where were you?** (25 min) Recall a moment when news reached you in an ordinary place. Describe the place in detail: what you remember and what you don't.

- [ ] **A letter you might send** (30 min) Draft a note to someone you trust telling them a hard truth gently. Notice what you choose to leave out.
- [ ] **Body check** (10 min) Note how you physically felt reading the stranger's accusations. Where did you feel it? Thrillers work on the body.
- [ ] **Prediction** (10 min) Write down what you think the credit-card charge will show and what Adam will do next.
- [ ] **Self-deception** (30 min) The chapter opens with Adam lying to himself. Write honestly about one story you tell yourself about your past.
- [ ] **Trust inventory** (20 min) List the people whose word you'd accept without checking. What earned it?
- [ ] **Reading ritual** (10 min) Decide where, when and how you'll read this book. Set up the ritual; note it in the reading log.

## Cross-room projects

### The Secret Ledger

Rooms: Room 233, Incident Board, Driveway

- [ ] Set up a notebook with columns: secret, keeper, who knows, status.
- [ ] Enter chapter 1's secrets.
- [ ] Pin the clues from chapter 1 on your incident board.
- [ ] Write a private journal note about your first reaction.
- [ ] Commit to adding one line per chapter.

### Cedarfield, Mapped

Rooms: Turnpike, Records Room, Diner

- [ ] Choose a real Bergen County town as a stand-in for Cedarfield.
- [ ] Research its demographics and school rankings.
- [ ] Paint a night map of your Cedarfield.
- [ ] Pin the Legion Hall and Atlantic City.
- [ ] Write a caption for the map in the novel's wry voice.

### Opening Lines Workshop

Rooms: Law Office, Library Stacks, Incident Board

- [ ] Collect ten thriller first lines.
- [ ] Classify them: memory, action, voice, setting.
- [ ] Analyse chapter 1's first lines in that frame.
- [ ] Write three openings for a story of your own.
- [ ] Share and vote with your group.

### The Ethics of Telling

Rooms: Lacrosse Field, Room 233, Driveway

- [ ] Read a short extract or summary of Sissela Bok on secrets.
- [ ] Apply the five ethical lenses to the stranger's visit.
- [ ] Hold a ten-minute debate.
- [ ] Write a private reflection on a truth you were glad, or sorry, to learn.

### Book Club Night One

Rooms: Price Kitchen, Diner, Room 233

- [ ] Plan a bar-snack menu.
- [ ] Make a short playlist for arrival.
- [ ] Pick the two book-club questions.
- [ ] Assign each member a character to watch.
- [ ] Agree on the reading pace.

### Sources Shelf

Rooms: Library Stacks, Records Room, Law Office

- [ ] Find the epigraph source and its date.
- [ ] Read a synopsis of The Wild Duck.
- [ ] Note one parallel in a paragraph.
- [ ] Add both to your reading shelf.
- [ ] Write the parallel into your commonplace book.

## Essay and writing prompts

1. Essay: The first chapter of The Stranger opens with a lie that its hero will tell himself. Argue how this self-deception prepares us for a novel about the lies we tell others.
2. Essay: Is the stranger a villain, a messenger or a moral agent? Using only chapter 1, build a case for one reading and acknowledge the evidence against it.
3. Creative: Write the same scene from Corinne's point of view at her conference, at the moment the stranger is speaking. She doesn't know yet. What is she doing?

## Further reading

- *The Wild Duck*, Henrik Ibsen (1884). An outsider insists a family must live in truth; compare the cost.
- *The Adventure of Charles Augustus Milverton*, Arthur Conan Doyle (1904). Holmes' verdict on a man who trades in secrets frames the stranger's moral position.
- *Secrets: On the Ethics of Concealment and Revelation*, Sissela Bok (1982). The classic philosophical study of when concealment and revelation are justified.
- *The Stranger (L'Étranger)*, Albert Camus (1942). Another "stranger" whose title is a judgement; set the two side by side.
- *The Rock (choruses)*, T. S. Eliot (1934). Read the choruses the epigraph comes from, in a library edition.
- *Tell No One*, Harlan Coben (2001). Coben's breakout standalone: an ordinary man, a past that won't stay buried.

- *Revolutionary Road*, Richard Yates (1961). The suburban marriage as a performance that cracks.
- *Gone Girl*, Gillian Flynn (2012). A contemporary marriage thriller built on who is lying to whom.
- *The Presentation of Self in Everyday Life*, Erving Goffman (1956). The sociology of "front stage" and "back stage" selves: a key to Cedarfield.

Your pages

# Commonplace pages

For your own notes, in your own words.

# Notes

# Notes

# Notes

# Notes

# Notes